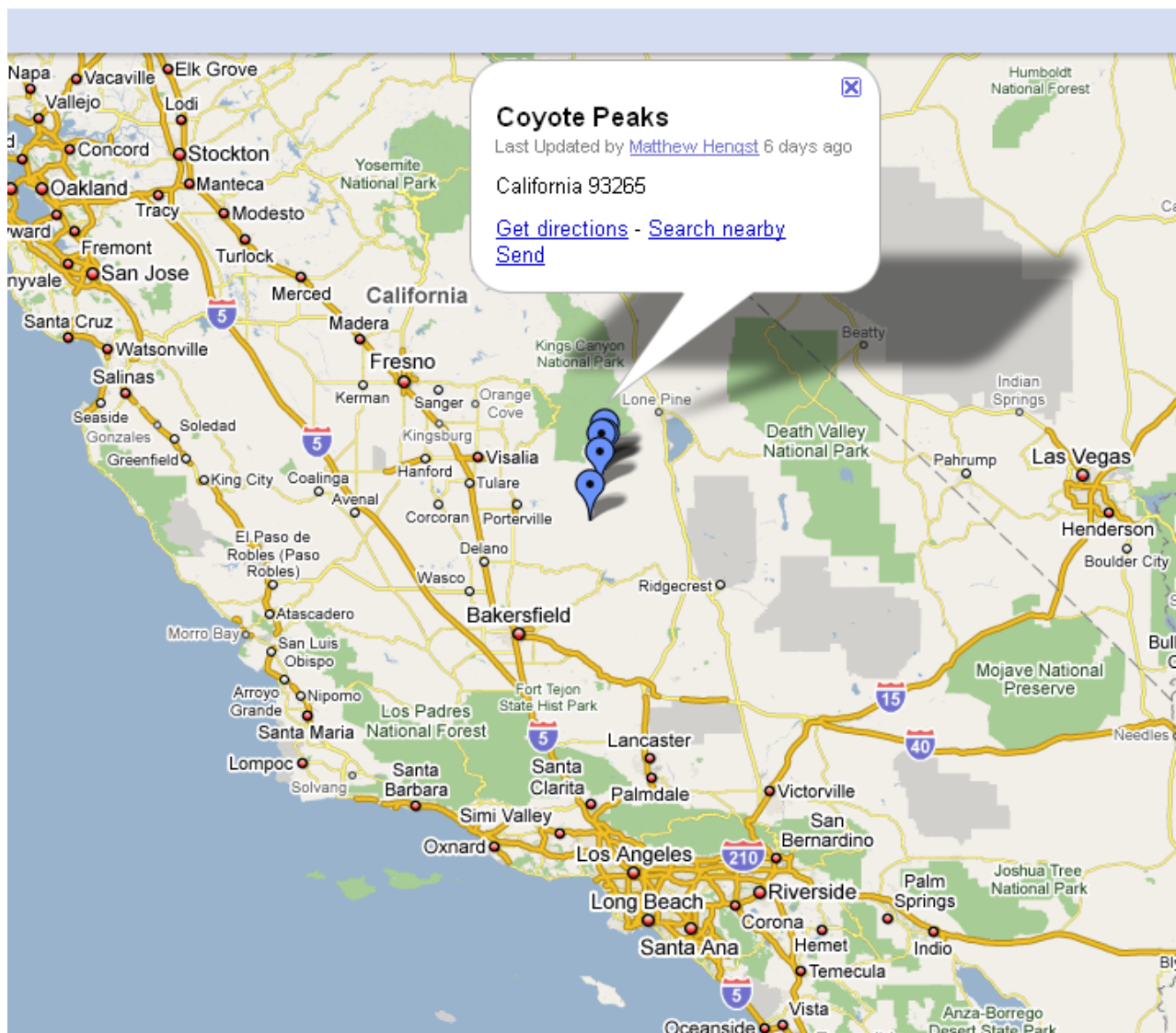


2009-05-23 to 2009-05-25 - Coyote & Angora SPS

This past weekend was the first of the trips into the Sierra that will take most of my weekends and vacation days over the course of the summer.

The hike was with a section of the Sierra Club mountaineering arm that I have limited experience with called SPS (Sierra Peak Section). While my usual group, the Hundred Peak Section, concentrates on local peaks in the greater LA area SPS gets into the more remote areas of the Sierras.



Coyote and Angora are remote but still in the Southern Sierra and not at a very high altitude. We actually topped out at 10,800 ft which is lower than some of the peaks around LA.

This was one of my rare weeks working from home so I was able to leave my house at 4 pm. Unfortunately it was the Friday before a holiday weekend so we didn't reach the trailhead until midnight.

When we arrived at the trailhead (which included a small campground with a few sites) everyone was asleep. We stumbled around in the dark and found what we believed to be our group but we weren't sure. I had this image of waking up the next morning surrounded by a bunch of strangers if we picked wrong.

We ended up finding a small patch of ground without too many plants and just laid out our foam pads in the dirt, climbed into our sleeping bags, and passing out.

The next morning we were awake at 5 and starting to get things organized for our 6:30 am departure.

As it turned out we picked correctly. We met the rest of our group and after the usual rush to get ready we were listening to our trailhead speech by none other than Dan Richter. You might know him from the movie 2001 Space Odyssey:



http://nymag.com/daily/entertainment/2008/04/dan_richter_on_playing_the_ape.html



Unfortunately we soon hit the first of our issues when Dan and the coleader Asher had to turn back due to a precautionary medical issue. As a result the trip was turned over to two other leaders, Paul and Steve, who had come along as participants. They did a great job but it was still a bummer for many of us who were looking forward to climbing with Dan and Asher.

So now two people lighter we continued up the trail.



The area we were in was beautiful forest terrain, a nice change from the striking rocky peaks you see in the high reaches. It actually reminded me of some of the local mountains like San Jacinto.



After about 5 miles we came to our first major milestone, the Little Kern River. There is a rather solid bridge spanning it so we didn't have to wade but it gave us a nice chance to relax and cool off a bit. There were some tents set up a bit further up stream but we didn't see anyone else.

Once we crossed the Little Kern the cross country section started. That was much steeper (and so much more fun!)



One of the most striking features as we walked through the woods was the vivid green patches where water was flowing or seeping down gullies.



After 11 or 12 miles we made it to ~8,000 ft and set up camp on the edge of a meadow.

This trip was my first field test of several different pieces of gear. One of those was a sleeping quilt, something used by many ultralight backpackers. Basically the theory goes that since the part of the sleeping bag under your body gets compressed you don't gain any insulation from it. Therefore you can save weight by removing the bottom of the bag and being left with a rectangular quilt. You use it by putting it over the top of you like a blanket and tucking in the sides.



My quilt comes from a small company called Jacks R Better and has the added feature that it can be worn around camp by opening a Velcro slit in the middle of the quilt, putting your head through it, then wrapping some ties around you to hold it against your body. It's a neat feature in the morning when it's cold and you have to leave your nice warm bag to cook breakfast outside. It wasn't real cold on this trip but I'd call it a successful test.

It had the added benefit of making you look absolutely ridiculous. 😊



In addition I was trying out a much lighter pack and combined all the gear was probably the lightest load I've carried on a backpack yet.



My tent and campsite.



The next morning we were up and ready to go at 6:30 am.



We left one person behind at camp after he came down with mild altitude sickness the day before. He had acclimated overnight but wasn't quite up to the 16 mile cross country haul we had planned for the day.



The first part of the hike was again through forest but now we were hitting altitude and starting to get some decent views.



We started to see snow on the ground but it was mostly just patches and you could see the water running off as it melted. I didn't have water proof boots on but that wasn't a hindrance.

They really improved when we came over the top of a ridge



We also got our first view of our peak, Coyote, and the lake bearing the same name.



We took the ridge and had a bit of a 3rd class scramble getting to the peak itself. Once there we had some awesome views.



Coyote was actually my first official SPS peaks. Only 200-some more to go...



We then backtracked, picked up another ridge and climbed the second peak, Angora.



In the distance we could actually make out the high point of the continental United States, Mt Whitney



We returned to camp before day and spend our second night at the meadow before hiking out the next morning.



We had a great group. Among us there was a PCT thru hiker from 2005, a JMT thru hiker from 2008, another guy who had done parts of the PC, and the replacement leader had spent 4 weeks on the mountain climbing the 8,000+ m peak generally considered the warm up for Everest. Then there were a few WTC students, one guy who had done the identical climb back on Memorial Day weekend 1989, and then general troublemakers' like myself. It was quite the collection of experiences.

And now I'm actually flying home in order to drive back up to the Sierra's and hike another peak called Homer's Nose. More pictures soon!